Chapter 2

Forests and Wild Animals

A forest is a large area of land covered with many trees and plants. Forests are very important for all of us.

Gifts of the forest

- Forests give us wood, fruits, nuts, honey, gum and many plants used as medicines.
- Trees give out oxygen and keep the air clean.
- The roots of trees hold the soil and stop it from being washed away.
- Forests help to bring rain.
- Forests are the homes of many birds, insects and animals.

Many communities have lived in forests for hundreds of years. They know the plants and animals very well. They take from the forest only what they need.

Wild animals of India

India is home to many wild animals. The tiger is our national animal, and the peacock is our national bird. Elephants live in the forests of Kerala, Karnataka and Assam. The one-horned rhinoceros lives in Assam. Asiatic lions are found only in the Gir forest of Gujarat.

Forests and animals in danger

When people cut down too many trees, animals lose their homes and food. Some people also hunt animals for their skin, tusks or horns. Because of this, the number of many animals has gone down.

Saving forests and animals

- National parks and wildlife sanctuaries are special areas where animals are kept safe and trees cannot be cut. Kaziranga National Park in Assam protects the one-horned rhinoceros. Gir National Park protects the Asiatic lion.
- Project Tiger was started in 1973 to save tigers. Special tiger reserves were made across India.
- In the 1970s, village women in the hills of Uttarakhand hugged trees to stop them from being cut down. This is known as the Chipko movement. "Chipko" means "to hug" or "to stick to".

What we can do

We can plant trees, use both sides of paper, and never harm animals or birds.

Let's think

1. Write three gifts that the forest gives us.
2. Where are Asiatic lions found?
3. What was the Chipko movement?

New words

sanctuary - a safe place where wild animals are protected
national animal - the animal chosen to stand for the country